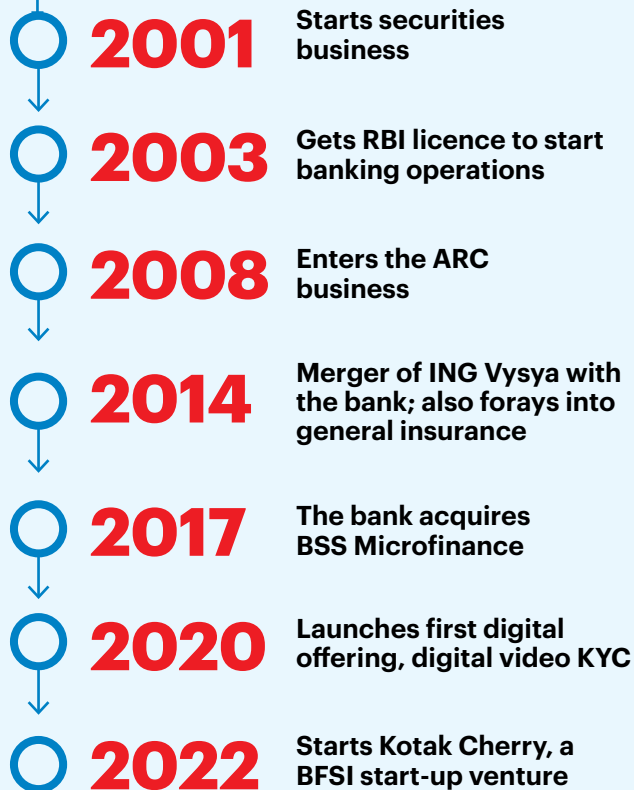




years ago, the government reached out to him to steer the failed infrastructure lender IL&FS out of asset-liability mismatches. In a four-year period, Kotak, who served as Non-executive Chairman of the IL&FS board, helped the NBFC recover a major part of the loans.

Kotak recently said that an institution has to out-live individuals, including those who founded it. “But like the water in an ocean, each contributory stream collectively makes up the institution,” he said in an address to shareholders this year. And there are global institutions that Kotak wants his group to emulate in the future. For instance, JP Morgan, the world’s largest bank by market capitalisation. It was started by John Morgan; after he passed away in 1913, his son, J.P. Morgan Jr. stepped into his shoes. The son then led the bank through tough times like World War I and the Great Depression. Later, professional leaders took over from the Morgan family to run the bank. And the global bank has only thrived.

Uday Kotak also appears to have built an institution that will stand the test of time, much like JP Morgan. **BT**

zonally. So, it requires a fundamental transformation of a bank from a traditional one that uses IT as a support function to one that operates more like a technology-centric and customer-first organisation. “There is a partnership model in play. We are integrating tech-savvy professionals who can collaborate with our banking experts. This ensures the delivery of products that not only meet banking standards but also resonate with the modern user’s expectations,” says Ekambaram. For instance, the IT and business teams sit together, take part in strategy decisions, and develop a product together. Such pairings, called “lighthouses”, are being established throughout KMB. This is part of the ‘Two-in-a-box’ strategy, wherein two leaders work together to make decisions and lead a team.

The centre of activity is not just the headquarters in Mumbai. Instead, the IT hubs—Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Gurugram—are the new innovation centres. The mobile banking team is based out of Mumbai, Gurugram, Hyderabad and Bengaluru, while the lead engineer operates from Hyderabad. And while the risk analytics team is in Mumbai, the person heading it is based in Bengaluru. “You have to be where the talent is,” says Nagnur. The new strategy is to build everything in-house to be available at all times without any delay or transaction failure. “What was done in three weeks by the vendor can now be done in two days. But this means we have to almost run an IT company inside the bank,” Nagnur adds.

The major investments are taking place in IT architecture, security, data analytics, and talent. “Today, technology complements business. But in the future, technology will be the business,” says Ekambaram. KMB wants its banking app to emulate popular ones like Amazon, or Swiggy—swift transitions, reliability, and consistent performance. That’s important because KMB’s mobile app is its largest branch. “Currently, 98